



China's Arctic Strategy: From “Follow-Up” to “Creative Involvement”?

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INTRODUCTION

A voice in the West believes that “for the Arctic, China seeks to pursue an economic development strategy for the region that requires that the Arctic be open to Chinese development and that China is given equal standing to other Arctic nations. This is the win-win strategy that Beijing is currently implementing in the Arctic” (Conley, 2018). *China's Arctic Policy White Paper* was published in January 2018, which “caused much consternation internationally, as it defined China as a ‘near-Arctic state’ and presented the idea of a ‘Polar Silk Road’ (PSR) linked to the Belt and Road Initiative (BRI)” (Klimenko, 2018), allowing journalists to develop a narrative about the country's interest and actions in the polar sphere (Moscato, 2018) “The release of the White Paper may have cleared some misconceptions about China's Arctic interest, but it lacks concrete

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steps or measures that China intends to implement in its Arctic policy” (Lim, 2018). However, “much remains uncertain on aspects of China’s key interests that are not addressed in the White Paper, in particular on the role of the Arctic in its national security and defence strategy” (Lim, 2018).

In accordance with positioning China as a “strategic rival” of the United States, a provocative speech by US Secretary of State Mike Pompeo of the Trump administration argued that “We’re entering a new age of strategic engagement in the Arctic ... There are only Arctic States and Non-Arctic States. No third category exists, and claiming otherwise entitles China to exactly nothing” (Pompeo, 2019). In response to this view, some critics argued that, “the key to U.S. policy toward China’s Arctic influence and activities should begin with solid assessment of China’s concrete capabilities instead of speculations about its intentions and potential” (Sun, 2020). It is worth noting that in recent years neither China’s “Near-Arctic State” self-identity in the Arctic nor the PSR confirmed in *China’s Arctic Policy White Paper* have been further implemented in paper or in practice.

In this context, a question is raised here: Is there any change occurring in China’s policy toward the changing Arctic? This study aims to examine the emerging shift of China’s Arctic policy from the past to the future. For this purpose, it outlines China’s “follow-up” strategy for the Arctic from 1999 to 2019 first, then it identifies consequential geo-strategic dates for the Arctic in the twenty-first century. Prospective scenarios of Arctic security dilemmas involving China and potential options available for China are highlighted in the following section. Finally, taking the practice of China’s climate diplomacy into account, it tries to explain China’s emerging alternative Arctic strategy characterized by “creative involvement.”

CHINA’S “FOLLOW-UP” STRATEGY FOR THE ARCTIC FROM 1999 TO 2019

Since the end of the twentieth century, Chinese presence in the Arctic has increased visibly and substantially, particularly in its scientific and economic activities, taking advantage of the rights and interests granted by the *Svalbard Treaty*. In 2020, a turning point for China’s Arctic engagement appeared due to increased uncertainties in the Arctic geo-strategic environment in the context of COVID-19. Thus, it is very

helpful to take China's Arctic involvement from 1999 to 2019 as a distinct period to view China's Arctic policy in practice.

During this period, milestones in China's Arctic involvement include: (1) From 1999 to the end of October 2019, China conducted 10 Arctic expeditions in total; (2) In 2004, China's first Arctic observation station, the Yellow River Station, was established in Svalbard; (3) In 2013, China gained permanent observer status in the Arctic Council; (4) In 2015, the Arctic (originally "polar regions" in Chinese) was connected for the first time to China's national security, in *Article 32 of China's National Security Law*; (5) In January 2017, Chinese President Xi Jinping positioned the polar regions (both the Arctic and Antarctic) as "new frontiers" along with the deep ocean, outer space and cyberspace; (6) Also in 2017, China and Russia proposed the concept of the "Polar Silk Road" ("Ice Silk Road"/"Arctic Silk Road") during Chinese President Xi's official visit to Moscow, connecting China's BRI with Russia's Eurasian Economic Union (EEU) plan through bilateral cooperation in the Russian Arctic region; (7) In January 2018, China published *China's Arctic Policy White Paper*; (8) In October 2018, the China-Iceland Arctic Research Observatory (CIAO) formally opened; (9) and in 2019, China's first self-built polar icebreaker Xuelong 2 was launched to boost China's polar research and expedition capabilities.

Based on the timeline of China's involvement in the Arctic, China's overall strategy for the Arctic can be defined as a "follow-up" strategy. According to the *Modern Chinese Dictionary*, "follow-up" (*Genjin* in Chinese) literally has four meanings, which are: follow and straightforward; quote or imitate others; step-by-step; and move forward as expected until completion. In this context, China's "follow-up" strategy for the Arctic refers to a gradual, step-by-step and non-coercive approach to Arctic affairs. Within its capacity, China prioritizes science diplomacy in the face of dramatic climate change and promotes economic and trade cooperation with other Arctic stakeholders for common development. China's competitive advantages in addressing Arctic affairs vary with its economic development and so does its "follow-up" strategy.

The "follow-up" strategy has two variants: "passive follow-up" and "active follow-up". Comparatively, from 1999 to 2012, China adopted a modest "passive follow-up" strategy for the Arctic. In the mid-1990s, Iceland attempted to persuade China to be involved in Arctic affairs during a special visit to Beijing, without eliciting expected responses. This indicates that the Arctic was not on China's agenda at that time.

However, after 2013, China switched to an “active follow-up” strategy after obtaining its observer status in the Arctic Council. In international media, China has been portrayed as a proactive, assertive, and ambitious Arctic player.

From a holistic perspective, China’s “follow-up” strategy in the Arctic has been closely related to China’s domestic economic development strategy and its diplomatic transition especially since 2009, resulting from two crucial background events. One is the international financial crisis that broke out in 2008/2009, and the other is China’s economic rise, which was highlighted in 2010 as China became the world’s second biggest economy after the United States. From the Chinese perspective, it is high time to pursue high-quality development based on the enormous wealth accumulation from its reform and opening-up policy pursued since 1979. Accordingly, China adjusted its foreign policy in order to adapt to a changing international environment. Out of internal demands and external stimulus, and despite China’s limited capacity for Arctic participation and unfavorable public opinion abroad, China determined to go North.

Compared with the United States and Russia, China’s limited capacity for Arctic participation makes China not yet a “new Polar Power” in terms of icebreakers, research stations, submarines, military bases, or allies. As a report goes, the United States has 6 military bases in the Arctic (Knickmeyer, 2022). Russia is said to have 19 military bases in the Arctic, and the United States has 2 icebreakers in service and plans 6 new icebreakers (Gilmour, 2018). “Russia officially has 46 icebreakers, including 4 nuclear-powered units”, and “the order of battle of the Northern Fleet comprises 41 submarines” (Boulègue, 2019). Based on Wikipedia, the United States has 3 research stations, while Russia has 9. According to the *Arctic Security Briefing Papers* of 2018, Russia operates up to 12 nuclear ballistic missile submarines (SSBNs) and 49 attack submarines, and the United States has 14 SSBNs not patrolling in the Arctic and operates 54 nuclear-powered attack submarines capable of operating under ice with regular forays into the Arctic (Ernie, 2018). Regarding allies, Russia has none in the Arctic region, but at the time of this writing the United States already has five (Canada, Norway, Denmark, Iceland, and Finland) with Sweden recently added as the sixth; While China has 2 icebreakers, 2 research stations, no submarines, no military bases and no allies in the Arctic. Thus a huge and stark gap exists between China and these two Arctic states regarding Arctic capacities.

In practice, China's "follow-up" strategy rests on three pillars. The first pillar is *science diplomacy*. Through scientific expeditions to the Arctic and sincere efforts in international organizations, like the International Arctic Science Committee (IASC), Chinese scientists are playing the role of door openers to make China's science diplomacy a success in the Arctic. China has made great progress in certain disciplines related to the Arctic over the past two decades. For instance, Chinese scientists have established the basic theoretical framework in cryosphere science, leading the writing of the fourth and the fifth reports by the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC). As Nalan Koc from Norway articulated before the start of the Arctic Frontiers 2020 to the Chinese media, "China is an important contributor to the Arctic research knowledge base" (Zhu, 2020).

The second pillar is *economic diplomacy*. Chinese economic activities particularly related to the energy and tourism sectors in the Arctic have been conducted in line with a grand blueprint. Among these, robust Sino-Russia economic cooperation in the region has been the highlight. According to Sanna Kopra, in June 2017 the Arctic was incorporated into China's BRI as one of the "blue economic passages" and China renamed Arctic shipping lanes as the PSR. "From 2005–2017, China has invested over \$1.4 trillion in the economies of the Arctic nations (including Finland and Sweden), \$89.2 billion of which was in infrastructure, assets, cooperative agreements, financing agreements, or other projects located within the 60 degrees north boundary ..." (Rosen and Thuringer, 2017). As Guggenheim Partners observes, "with a population of more than 12 million people and an annual economy of more than US\$450 billion, the Arctic represents one of the last great economic frontiers. Today, the economies of the Arctic are responsible for a significant share of the world's food, minerals, and energy" (Guggenheim Partners, 2016).

The third pillar is *public diplomacy*. As part of China's public diplomacy, academic exchanges on different platforms among universities and institutes from China and other Arctic stakeholders are booming. Along with promoting traditional governmental relations, public diplomacy has become an alternative for China to strengthen its relations with Arctic states bilaterally and multilaterally. For instance, "panda diplomacy" has been considered for decades to be effective for China to develop closer relations with the outside world. However, it should not be seen as a panacea suitable for all cases, given negative feedback from some Arctic

states. Through connecting its own reindeer Ewenki people in the Northeast of China with cross-border indigenous peoples in the Arctic, China has both new opportunities as well as challenges in developing its public diplomacy in the Arctic region in a productive manner.

GEO-STRATEGICALLY CONSEQUENTIAL DATES FOR THE ARCTIC IN THE TWENTY-FIRST CENTURY

Over the past decade, there were two consequential geostrategic dates for the Arctic (Conley and Melino, 2020): One was May 28, 2008, when the “Arctic Five”, namely, Russia, Canada, Norway, Denmark (Greenland), and the United States, signed the Ilulissat Declaration, which reaffirmed that the Arctic would be governed by the UN Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS). And the other was May 15, 2013, when China became an observer to the Arctic Council, an intergovernmental forum designed to protect the Arctic environment and to explore the sustainable development of the Arctic region. Since then, China, a self-declared “near-Arctic state”, has substantially accelerated its economic and scientific presence across the circumpolar Arctic, and in subsequent years, China started to collaborate with Russia in military exercises in the Arctic (Conley and Melino, 2020). This analysis obviously served as a reflection of the reality of Arctic geopolitics in the past several years due to their recognition of great power competition in the Arctic region. It is fair to say that the importance of the “Arctic Five” and China are exaggerated, as China was imaged as a “near-peer competitor” of the United States in the Arctic.

In this sense, as a revision and supplement to related works, four geostrategically consequential dates for the Arctic need to be mentioned here in order to elucidate the changing Arctic geopolitics. Each and every big event marked a turning point for Arctic geopolitics: (1) In August 2007, Russians planted their flag in the seabed at the North Pole during Artur Chilingarov’s expedition; (2) In March 2014, when the Ukraine crisis broke out and Crimea was annexed to Russia; (3) In May 2019, as mentioned previously, Pompeo gave a speech in Finland, launching a new era of power competition in the Arctic region; (4) In February 2022, Russia launched its self-defined “special military operation” against Ukraine.

Big Event 1: On August 2, 2007, a pair of Russian submersibles dropped 4267 meters to the bottom of the Arctic Ocean and planted a

Russian flag at the North Pole. This action disturbed the overall peaceful and stable geopolitical pattern in the Arctic after the end of the Cold War and provoked strong reactions and serious concerns from other Arctic states. A deputy spokesman for the US State Department responded that Russia's claim to Arctic sovereignty in this manner had no legal force. Then the Canadian Foreign Minister criticized it as not supporting Russia's territorial claims in the Arctic. Arctic states such as Denmark and Norway, disapproving of Russia's approach, responded by taking concrete steps to strengthen their jurisdiction and monitoring of their Arctic territories. In this atmosphere, Arctic states including Canada, Norway, Denmark, and the United States submitted their boundary claims to the UN Commission on the Limits of the Continental Shelf (UNCLOS), although the United States had never ratified the UNCLOS.

Interestingly, the reverberations from this event also reached China. "In 2007, Chinese strategic thinkers started to take a geopolitical interest in the Arctic after Russian explorers planted a national flag on the seabed at the North Pole. Since then, a gradual awakening has taken place among Chinese Government officials and social science researchers regarding the need to prepare for the day when most of the Arctic will be accessible, at least during the summer" (Jakobson and Peng, 2012). Meanwhile, in the field of International Relations, the first academic article on the Arctic in Chinese was also published in 2007, focusing on the "Arctic Race" (Wu, 2007), aroused by Russia's flag-planting event. Considering that China had already begun applying for observer status in the Arctic Council, the reaction of Chinese academic and policy circles at the time was not, in retrospect, simply a coincidence. Russia's flag-planting in the Arctic Ocean stimulated the interest of countries outside the region such as China, Japan, South Korea, India, and Singapore, and the eventual admission of these countries simultaneously into the Arctic Council in May 2013, clearly reflected geopolitical considerations as well.

Big Event 2: On March 18, 2014, the former Autonomous Republic of Crimea of Ukraine was annexed to the Russian Federation, namely the "Crimean Incident". As a response, the United States and the European Union simultaneously announced a new round of sanctions against Russia. The deteriorating relations between Russia, the United States and the European Union intensified international speculation about the return of a "new Cold War". In the long run, the geopolitical changes induced by the Crimean Incident are closely related to the development and general evolution of the global geopolitical pattern. In the Arctic

region, this incident and the subsequent Western sanctions forced Russia to lose the US and European markets for its liquefied natural gas (LNG) projects, and turn to the East, accelerating its cooperation with East Asian countries, especially with China, in areas including the utilization of the Northern Sea Route, energy exploration and related infrastructure construction. Among these, the success of the Yamal project is regarded as the biggest merit of China–Russia Arctic cooperation. For Russia, China is the best partner for developing Siberia and realizing its strategic mission in the Far East. In turn, “in a very short time, China has become a full-fledged participant in the economic and political processes in the Arctic” (Miheeva, 2019), which largely owes to Russia’s leverage.

Although the two countries may face new competition with respect to the governance of the Northern Sea Route in the future, it is undeniable that China–Russia cooperation based on mutual respect in the Arctic region is so far pragmatic and effective. The approaches of China and Russia in the Arctic are also strong geopolitical stimuli to other Arctic stakeholders. China and Russia are both now considered to be “strategic competitors” that pose a long-term threat to the United States in the Arctic. The Crimean Incident is the bond between China and Russia for closer Arctic cooperation and the fuse for the deterioration of relations between Russia and the West. Compared to the event of Russia’s flag-planting in the Arctic in 2007, the Crimean Incident has had a much more profound impact on Arctic geopolitics as it demonstrated that military might was revived as a way to deal with disputes.

Big Event 3: On May 6, 2019, Pompeo gave a speech in Finland, changing the long-standing perception of the Arctic as a region of “high North, low tension” after the end of the Cold War. Influential consequences of this speech are reflected not only in the shift of the paradigm of Arctic security research but also in the position, policy, and path of the United States against China and Russia in its national strategies. By the end of Trump’s presidency, the US government was actively treating China as a perceived enemy. The United States pressured Nordic states, requiring a definition of “Chinese threat in the Arctic;” this led to the Nordic states wavering in their stance on China’s Arctic participation. “The Faroe Islands have turned into a new and unlikely battleground in the technological Cold War between the United States and China” (Satariano, 2019) as the United States urged the archipelago not to

give the 5G network contract to Huawei, the Chinese telecommunications giant (regarding Japan's parallel strategy of presenting China as a revisionist power in the Arctic, see Midford's chapter in this volume).

Pompeo's speech and the US confrontational policy moves also can be found in the Biden administration's Arctic policy. In his speech on US foreign policy on February 4, 2021, US President Joseph R. Biden declared that in working with American allies and partners "we'll also take on directly the challenges posed to our prosperity, security, and democratic values by our most serious competitor, China" (The White House, 2021a). "To the People's Republic of China, we'll compete with confidence; we'll cooperate wherever we can; we'll contest where we must" (Blinken, 2022). Thus, dealing with the so-called "China Challenge" is still a priority for US policy toward the Arctic in Biden's administration, and the two-wheel model of China-US relations driven by competition and cooperation in the Arctic is roughly predictable.

Big Event 4: On February 24, 2022, Russia launched its self-defined "special military operation" against Ukraine. In the context of the Russia-Ukraine conflict, the increasing high tension between Russia and the West stands out with Western sanctions on Russia and Russia's counter-sanctions on the West. As of the writing of this chapter, the spillover effect of the Russia-Ukraine conflict into the Arctic is exactly what deserves sincere concern.

First, the spillover effect of Russia-Ukraine conflict on the Arctic governance system: the system would be split into two parts, one dominated by the West and the other by Russia. The facts are as follows: In March 2022, the other seven Arctic states (A7) as well as members of the Arctic Council excluded Russia from the Arctic governance system, including the Arctic Council, Arctic Economic Council, Nordic Council of Ministers, Northern Dimensions, Barents Euro-Arctic Council. As a response, in May 2022, Russia withdrew from the Council of the Baltic Sea States.

Second, the spillover effect of Russia-Ukraine conflict on Arctic security framework: NATO began to expand in the north. On May 18, 2022, Finland and Sweden formally submitted their applications for NATO membership. The accession protocols for Finland and Sweden were signed on July 5, 2022, after completion of accession talks. On April 4, 2023, Finland formally became a member of NATO. However, Swedish NATO membership was delayed until recently due to delayed ratification by Hungary and Turkey.

Third, the spillover effect of Russia–Ukraine conflict on Arctic international scientific and technological cooperation: such cooperation is being politicalized and securitized. In March 2022, the IASC proclaimed its support for the Arctic Council’s standpoint on the Russia–Ukraine conflict. In April 2022, the document *France’s Polar Strategy for 2030: Balancing the Extremes* declared France’s decision to halt its plan to co-organize the 4th edition of the Arctic Science Ministerial with Russia in 2023. In June 2022, the *Guidance On Scientific and Technological Cooperation with the Russian Federation for US Government and US Government Affiliated Organizations* stated that the United States had taken “active measures to limit bilateral science and technology research cooperation with the Russian government” (The White House, 2022b) in which the Arctic-related science and technology research cooperation is included.

PROSPECTIVE SCENARIOS OF ARCTIC SECURITY DILEMMAS INVOLVING CHINA AND POTENTIAL CHINESE OPTIONS

Confronting increased uncertainties in the Arctic security strategy environment analyzed above, three scenarios regarding possible Arctic security dilemmas that are plausible in the future are summarized here, inducing potential options for China—an important Arctic stakeholder.

Scenario 1: *An emerging China–US–Russia strategic triangle*

There have been discussions about the Arctic strategic triangle in recent years. The “New Arctic Strategic Triangle Environment” in which “the primary security requirements of the three most powerful states are now overlapping in the Arctic region” (Huebert, 2019). In the meantime, “the potential for Russia and China to cooperate in opposing US interests” (Pincus, 2020) in the Arctic was highly emphasized in academia. Some identify the existing pressure points in the Sino-Russian strategic partnership, and advise the United States to exploit these to prevent energy collaboration between China and Russia from becoming military collaboration (Leddy and Lurie, 2020). They further suggest that the United States cooperate with China where possible and compete when necessary. The US *National Strategy for the Arctic Region* issued in October 2022 emphasizes that China “seeks to increase its influence in the Arctic through an expanded slate of economic, diplomatic, scientific, and military activities” (The White House, 2022a). In this context, the assumption that the formation of the China–US–Russia strategic triangle is taking place in the Arctic region seems not to be an illusion.

Scenario 2: A new Cold War between China–Russia and US-NATO in the Arctic region

In May 2020, the Trump administration published a report entitled *United States Strategic Approach to the People's Republic of China*, which in some social media in China is considered to be a declaration of a new Cold War between the United States and China against the background of the "Trade War", the "Science and Technology War" and the "Financial War" between these two countries. In recent years, the decoupling measures taken by the United States with respect to China have dramatically expanded to the field of cultural communications and exchange. Moreover, in a 2020 Nordic foreign and security policy report Nordic states also expressed concerns about the rivalry among great powers as well as the return of Cold War in the Arctic given that the United States considers China's presence in the Arctic as a threat to its national interests (Bjarnason, 2020). Considering the spillover effect of Russia–Ukraine conflict on the Arctic as noted previously, especially the "hybrid tensions between Russia and the other Arctic states (...) rampant in the 2020s" (Kauppila and Kopra, 2022), a new Cold War between China–Russia and US-NATO in the Arctic region cannot be dismissed.

Scenario 3: A period with China being a solo player in geopolitical chaos

In the wake of the Russia–Ukraine conflict, a period of geopolitical chaos in the Arctic seems to replace the high geopolitical stability that Heininen highly appreciated as exceptional in world politics and IR. The future of the Arctic Council is caught up in a heated debate. The A7 have reinforced their solidarity within the Arctic Council excluding Russia. Russia accordingly amended its state Arctic policy to 2035 prioritizing its "national interest" and removing cooperation within the Arctic Council (Humpert, 2023). At the same time, countries including South Africa, Brazil, and Russia are shaping common interests in Arctic collaboration. In this case, China is dragged into another dilemma. The Arctic Council has been a primary platform for Chinese participation in Arctic affairs since 2013; China joined all six of its working groups as an observer. Then how should China position itself in the virtually "new" Arctic Council without Russia? Is China still legal as an observer of the Arctic Council? Should China join Russia's growing circle of friends aiming to explore cooperation in the Arctic Zone of Russian Federation (AZRF)? Or should China be a solo player maintaining the freedom of choice in hand?

These three scenarios of Arctic security actually represent three types of dilemmas for China when dealing with Arctic issues. In terms of the

degree of China's engagement in Arctic global governance in the years to come, there are three potential options for China, each accompanied by their own unavoidable duality.

Option 1: *A position to the left—China continues to increase investment in the Arctic and seeks leadership in Arctic global governance*

In this approach, China would be assertive on those security issues related to the Arctic. On traditional security issues, according to the spirit of the UN Charter and basic principles of international law, China would make its own voice be heard in the international arena, providing solutions for tough problems and not excluding creating new international mechanisms and platforms to discuss security issues. On non-traditional security issues, focusing on the Arctic region, China would play a leading role in international rules-making, such as fulfilling her international promise to become carbon neutral, leading the global response to climate change effectively, advocating public health emergency treatment, organizing joint search-and-rescue, etc.

Considering China's capacity for Arctic involvement at the moment, this might be a "great leap". From a positive perspective, as its overall national strength continues to grow, China might gain an institutional say in Arctic affairs, which would help China play a greater and more constructive role in Arctic sustainable development. At the same time, Arctic states and other stakeholders would get a free ride on China's high-quality development in a more reasonable way, and the prospect of an expected "Arctic community of shared future" may be foreseeable.

On the negative side, the cost for China to obtain and maintain leadership in the Arctic might grow beyond its expectations since China's leadership would not likely be welcomed by other Arctic stakeholders, especially by the Arctic states. In that case, the Arctic geopolitics would be changed fundamentally and not favorably for China as well. On the one hand, only with the internal support of China's economic and social prosperity and progress can China mobilize the resources and capabilities needed to navigate the Arctic. On the other hand, China must realize the cost of imagined power transfer in the Arctic as the so-called "Thucydides Trap" describes, which cannot be completely ruled out. Meanwhile, China may face the risk of being entangled in great power competition in the Arctic, leading to disastrous results.

Option 2: *A position to the right—China withdraws from the Arctic to avoid unbearable geopolitical risks*

In this case, China would carry out a comprehensive strategic contraction, consciously avoiding the potential risk of a conflict with the United States and the West in the Arctic region in the political, diplomatic, economic, and military fields. Under adverse circumstances, China might even unilaterally withdraw from Arctic affairs, even from the Arctic Council and the *Arctic Ocean Fisheries Agreement*, and those projects with Chinese investment. Due to the limited scope of the Arctic Council without Russia, China owns the opportunity to quit when the Arctic Council is at a historical turning point. However, such a move would actually equal a freeze in policy in China–Arctic relations.

China's withdrawal would be altruistic as it would probably have beneficial consequences for stakeholders in the Arctic, especially the Arctic states. They would no longer worry about the so-called "Chinese threat in the Arctic" or deal with the "China Challenge" they are trying to define, thus relatively ensuring mutual security. In the same way, China would not worry about the risk of so-called "strategic overdraft", or the attack by adverse international opinions.

In the context of climate change, the atmosphere, ocean currents, information, and other security-related elements are all in motion. The interaction between a globalized Arctic and a rising China is inevitable. In the process of Chinese modernization, China needs a more abundant resource reserve and a truly global strategic vision, while the Arctic states cannot undertake all the tasks of global governance and sustainable development of the Arctic on their own. Such an artificial break in China–Arctic interaction would not be beneficial for either side. China will not obtain reliable resources and energy from the Arctic region, and the Arctic countries will not profit from China's hypermarket alike.

Option 3: *A position on the middle road—China pursues a new strategic balance with "creative involvement"*

China would focus on the issues of low politics such as environmental protection and sustainable development through the Arctic Council. Regarding non-traditional security issues, China would seek to provide international public goods to deal with common challenges. It would accordingly strengthen its climate diplomacy, science and technology diplomacy, public diplomacy, etc. China's creative involvement in international disputes in the Arctic region would be a reasonable option if necessary. Detailed measures such as international aid in the form of large-scale engineering projects, peacekeeping operations, diplomatic

mediation, and disaster relief under the framework of the United Nations are included in this sense.

Adhering to the Chinese traditional philosophy highlighted by the Golden Mean (*Zhong Yong Zhi Dao* in Chinese), this approach of maintaining a strategic balance using creative involvement is a positive and progressive choice for China. With the joint efforts of China and other Arctic stakeholders based on common interests and mutual respect in an interconnected world, a new Arctic order with the forces of all parties moving toward balance would be forged. China would play an important but non-dominant role in this respect, rather than continuing the great power game under the Cold War mentality. This would likely achieve a win-win or all-win situation, which is the most desirable model for China–Arctic relation.

Inevitably, however, this choice is also flawed. As mentioned earlier, traditional and non-traditional security appears to be intertwined with each other from paper to practice, which would make China's efforts to divide the one into two difficult to achieve. At the same time, China's increased activities in the Arctic have been accompanied by negative speculations among Arctic states about China's strategic intentions in the Arctic. As a result, the so-called "Chinese threat in the Arctic" will remain strong and fierce in international public opinion dominated by the West, while China's vision of seeking a new geopolitical balance in the Arctic may be in danger of becoming unbalanced.

CHINA'S EMERGING NEW ARCTIC STRATEGY CHARACTERIZED BY "CREATIVE INVOLVEMENT"

From the perspective of both its domestic and international situations, China's "follow-up" strategy, which was applied to Arctic affairs from 1999 to 2019, has become untenable in the last couple of years. On the one hand, the "follow-up" strategy for the Arctic cannot meet China's new vision of development. Domestically, China is accelerating the formation of a new pattern of development in which domestic cycles are the mainstay and domestic and international cycles supplement each other. This new pattern of economic development is, to some extent, a pragmatic Chinese strategy to counter the US-initiated trade war, science and technology war, and financial war, and the waves of anti-globalization. Ensuring the safety of domestic and international industrial chains has

become the top priority for China to promote its high-quality development. This is essentially an innovation-driven development approach, which largely requires a diplomacy with initiatives and creativity to match. Diplomacy is a political continuation of domestic affairs at large, which has not been changed in China since the reform and opening-up policy of the late 1970s. Under this principle, as part of the "strategic new frontier," the Arctic is definitely a testing field in theory to justify China's new policy.

On the other hand, the growing difficulties encountered by Chinese companies also signal the end of the "follow-up" strategy; this was inevitable. In 2019 alone, failures suffered by Chinese companies rose sharply. Here are some typical cases: (1) Continuous controversies over a proposed railway corridor collaborating with Finland led to a negative evaluation and a consequential final suspension on China's side; (2) Chinese firms lost a bid for airport construction in Greenland; and (3) Chinese companies were expelled from the Alaska LNG project estimated at \$43 billion, although there was a nonbinding joint development agreement signed during then US President Trump's visit to China in November 2017. "In recent years the gap between Chinese preferences regarding the PSR and its actual capabilities and accomplishments has dramatically widened ... (the) impact (of the PSR) on the far north is far less significant than what was originally predicted, while the Russian invasion of Ukraine has, if anything, pushed Chinese Arctic policies even further backwards" (Lanteigne, 2022). Facing the serious damages to China's legitimate rights and interests as well as its national image in the Arctic, China's strategy for the Arctic is bound to take an assertive turn.

On China's diplomatic transformation in Arctic affairs, theoretical preparations have emerged from Chinese academia since 2010s. Wang Yizhou, a representative of globalism in China, proposed the innovative

concept of “creative involvement”¹ in 2011, arousing extensive discussions and debates about China’s diplomatic transformation both at home and abroad. “The creative involvement can be implemented in a selective, constructive and restrictive approach with prudent decisions on timing, means and content, rather than simply rely on military repression or directly confront with violence” (Wang, 2012).

In this context, two types of behaviors can comprise the “creativity” in “creative involvement”. One is independent initiative: active advocacy inspired and stimulated by the internal and external environment. And the other is a dependent response: passive response to the pressure and stimulation of internal and external environment. The “involvement” in “creative involvement” can be divided into material and non-material involvement under the influence of internal and external environments. Material involvement is mainly the explicit input of funds, goods, facilities, equipment, weapons, and technical installations. For instance, commercial international aid is in the form of large engineering projects. Non-material involvement includes implicit input to the legal system, rules, values, and ideology by means of personnel, including soldiers such as in peace-keeping operations, diplomatic mediation, and disaster relief under the UN framework. A typological analysis of creative involvement is shown in Table 7.1.

Driven by both the pressing situation and inspired by the “creative involvement” theory, China has made new changes in its climate diplomacy related to Arctic global governance. In 2016, the Standing Committee of the National People’s Congress approved China’s accession to the Paris Agreement on Climate Change with proactive implementation in the following years. “China is making greater and faster strides than expected away from fossil fuels—becoming the world’s largest investor in solar and wind technology and boasting more jobs in solar energy than in coal-mining. It’s all part of a long-term economic strategy

¹ Wang Yizhou’s works about creative involvement include: *The Theory of Contemporary International Politics* (Shanghai: Shanghai People’s Publishing House, 1995), *Global Politics and China’s Foreign Diplomacy* (Beijing: World Affairs Press, 2003), *International Relations in a Globalized Perspective* (Beijing: Peking University Press, 2005), *Creative Involvement: A New Direction in China’s Diplomacy* (Beijing: Peking University Press, 2011), *Creative Involvement: The Evolution of China’s Global Role* (Beijing: Peking University Press, 2013), *Ten Issues on China Foreign Affairs* (Jiangsu People’s Publishing House, 2015), and *Creative Involvement: The Transition of China’s Diplomacy* (Beijing: Peking University Press, 2015).

Table 7.1 A typological analysis of creative involvement

<i>Internal environment</i>	<i>Material involvement</i>	<i>Non-material involvement</i>
<i>External environment</i>		
Dependent response	Material involvement with dependent response	Non-material involvement with dependent responsive
Independent initiative	Material involvement with independent initiative	Non-material involvement with independent initiative

Source Author created table

to dominate in critical technologies” (Savage, 2019). With the Trump administration’s decision to withdraw from the Paris Agreement in 2017, “the United States has opened up the opportunity for China to gain a competitive advantage and a leadership role in regard to global climate issues, as demonstrated by China’s aggressive investments in renewable energy, increased energy efficiency, and economic policies that focus on lowering energy usage and greenhouse gas emissions” (Gallagher and Zhang, 2019). Notably, China’s diplomatic investment in climate actions has been remarkable. “By the end of 2017, China’s domestic carbon intensity had fallen by 46%, reaching the upper limit target of 40-45% three years ahead of schedule. Renewable energy accounts for 13.8% of primary energy, still some way short of 15%, but the target is set to be reached by 2020. Forest stock has increased by 2.1 billion cubic meters, exceeding the 2020 target.” (The State Council Information Office of the People’s Republic of China, 2018). And “China will scale up its Intended Nationally Determined Contributions by adopting more vigorous policies and measures. We aim to have CO₂ emissions peak before 2030 and achieve carbon neutrality before 2060” (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the People’s Republic of China, 2020).

In January 2021, US President Biden signed an executive order to make the United States rejoin the Paris Agreement on Climate Change. Under this circumstance, the dialogue and cooperation on climate change between China and the United States resumed with impressive results. In November 2021, two joint statements on addressing climate change were signed by China’s Special Envoy for Climate Change Xie Zhenhua and US Special Presidential Envoy for Climate John Kerry. One is entitled “China–US Joint Statement Addressing the Climate Crisis issued in April 2021” and the other is “China–US Joint Glasgow Declaration

on Enhancing Climate Action in the 2020s”. According to the latter agreement, “the two sides intend to establish a ‘Working Group on Enhancing Climate Action in the 2020s,’ which will meet regularly to address the climate crisis and advance the multilateral process, focusing on enhancing concrete actions in this decade” (U.S. Department of State, 2021). “The documents were set to enter the implementation phase when the visit (of US House Speaker Nancy Pelosi to Taiwan in August 2022) that infringed on China’s sovereignty and territorial integrity happened, forcing China to suspend the Sino-US climate talks” (Hou, 2021). On the US side, “US climate envoy John Kerry praised China’s efforts at tackling global warming and urged Beijing to resume suspended talks on the issue, even as tensions flare with Washington over the status of Taiwan” (Varvitsioti and Williams, 2022).

Among the four pillars of the *US National Strategy for the Arctic Region*, climate change and environmental protection are highlighted as Pillar 2. The document implies that dealing with climate change is supposed to be the priority of the US Arctic agenda from 2022 to 2032. In the meanwhile, “despite its suspension of climate talks with the United States, China has always been a proactive contributor to the global climate process with persistent endeavors to support other developing countries” (Hou, 2021). In this sense, China is still taking a leading role in dealing with global climate crisis with its “creative involvement”. Assuming that China applies the “creative involvement” doctrine the Arctic region, and to the extent that domestic politics of the United States allows, China and the United States might be able to cooperate again on climate change as a breakthrough in the context of troubled bilateral relations. However, it is not to be ignored that competition between China and the United States for leadership in combating Arctic climate change is possible. For example, President Biden again positioned China as a long-term strategic competitor at the 2021 Virtual Munich Security Conference, stating that “competition with China is going to be stiff” (The White House, 2021b). In this sense, in order to achieve the win-win situation for China, the United States, and the Arctic as a whole, it is time and imperative for China to leverage its creative involvement strategy in the Arctic to replace its previous “follow-up” strategy.

CONCLUSIONS

This chapter highlights China's "follow-up" strategy for the Arctic from 1999 to 2019, which refers to the gradual, step-by-step, and non-coercive approach China adopted in addressing Arctic affairs within its capacity. It prioritized science diplomacy in the face of dramatic climate change and boosted economic and trade cooperation with other Arctic stakeholders in the interests of common development. China's "follow-up" strategy for the Arctic varied with its economic development, which comprises three pillars, namely, science diplomacy, economic diplomacy, and public diplomacy.

However, two other geo-strategically consequential dates for the Arctic appeared, which complicated the Arctic security environment: Pompeo's speech of 2019 in Finland and the Russian "special military operation" against Ukraine since February 2022. Under the circumstances, three scenarios regarding an Arctic security dilemma are likely in the future, namely: (1) an emerging China-US-Russia strategic triangle; (2) a new Cold War between China-Russia and US-NATO in the Arctic region; and (3) a period with China being a solo player in geopolitical chaos. These three scenarios accordingly create three potential options for China's future engagement in Arctic global governance: (1) China continues to increase investment in the Arctic and seeks leadership in Arctic global governance; (2) China withdraws from the Arctic to avoid unbearable geopolitical risks; and (3) China pursues a new strategic balance with "creative involvement". Considering the increasing risks and uncertainties against the background of COVID-19 and the Russia-Ukraine conflict, it is clear that China's legitimate rights and interests as well as its image in the Arctic were damaged unexpectedly in terms of the implementation of the PSR. This situation urgently necessitates the end of China's "follow-up" strategy in the Arctic, accompanied by a rethink of the PSR.

China's new changes in its climate diplomacy indicate that a shift of China's Arctic strategy from "follow-up" to "creative involvement" is taking place. China's rich experiences and a rising role in addressing global climate change over the years, especially during the United States' absence from the Paris Agreement, have provided an opportunity for China to update its Arctic strategy. It is the idea of "creative involvement" that is supposed to pull China out of the security dilemma caused by the deterioration in Arctic geopolitics. Given the United States values its cooperation with China in climate change in the Arctic, China's creative involvement

is to create a win-win situation. In the face of the new reality, it is time for China to leverage its “creative involvement” strategy for the Arctic to replace its previous deficient “follow-up” strategy, thereby implementing China’s global self-image as a responsible great power on the international stage.

In a word, considering the complexity of cooperation, competition, and confrontation China faces in participating in Arctic affairs in the future, China’s new promising and aggressive strategy of “creative involvement” should be taken seriously. With the emergence of creative involvement in the Arctic as part of China’s overall foreign policy, we would say that China’s Arctic policy is in transition, not on paper, but in practice.

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